

ART115 Animation I (2D)

Semester: Fall 2026

Location: Alumni Hall, Room 302

Days/Times: M/W/F 2:00-2:50am

Instructor: Mark Baldridge

Email: mbaldridge@albright.edu

Student Hours: Fridays 9am to Noon —other times by appointment

Office: 345 Science Hall

PRO-TIP: *When emailing any professor about a course, begin the "Subject" line with the course number or name -then clearly state your reason for writing*

Introduction

From the catalog:

A time-based medium, animation adopts ideas and approaches from graphic design and performance to create the illusion of motion, define characters and tell stories. Tools and techniques of 2D animation (which may include approaches to 3D) will be explored by students in this course.

We'll take a key word from the description above and define animation as methods for creating an:

Illusion of Life

Within this context we'll explore:

- **Rhythm**

Visual or sonic, in space or time, rhythm provides structure —it's one of the most dynamic principles of design

The exploration of rhythm pays dividends in many fields of creative activity

- **Character**

From "flour sacks" and other abstract shapes, up to photorealistic human beings, character comes down to personality, a sense of autonomy, goal-seeking behavior

- **Meaning**

Feeling is first. This is what we talk of when referring to the "expressiveness" of a medium

Intention, messaging, advertising? Feeling is the carrier wave on which they ride

Goals and Objectives

Instructional Goals:

- Build a foundation in the fundamentals of animation
- Explore the relation between character and narrative
- Learn to tell stories with animation

Learning Objectives

- **Technical Proficiency** Move shapes and colors around in space, demonstrating spacial and temporal rhythm
 - **Conceptual** Create and animate characters with personality, discover how character *generates* narrative
 - **Developmental** Learn to control emotional effects to create satisfying experiences
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Computing Requirements

If you own a laptop, you should bring it to class. The classroom should come with Photoshop, Illustrator and After Effects installed on lab machines
Toward the end of the course we may wish to approach 3D animation with Blender 3D, or other free software, this may be installed on student laptops

Organization

Portfolio

You will never email or give me your assignment (unless asked, for troubleshooting purposes) but will keep and preserve your work in a digital portfolio.

For source files, you may use a google drive — for video files, a youtube channel. Tho if you prefer ftp and Vimeo or some other combo, this is up to you!

I don't wish you to preserve your work in any space tied to your student email. I want you to have access to this material long after graduation, and indeed until you decide to archive or delete it!

If a Google Drive folder, your instructor will want it to be shared by a particular, preferred method:

LINK: [How to share a Google Drive folder with your instructor](#)

You are required to follow this tutorial if using Google Drive!

This kind of digital portfolio is only a few steps away from a *professional* version, useful for applying for gigs, gradschool or etc.

Your professor will always be eager and ready to help you develop a professional portfolio!

Projects

In this course we will produce three Projects

- **Abstractions** gives us a chance to play with rhythm in space and time, to experiment with textures and sync sound
- In **Characters tell Stories** we'll learn that contrasting characters in carefully chosen situations generate stories on their own
- **Advance!** Gives us a chance to try out some new techniques, more fully develop our ideas and projects or introduce new technologies or softwares (This may include interactivity, depending on student interest)

Evaluation

All course work will be evaluated on the basis of a 100-point semester

- **Tutorial Assignments**
 - Each of these is calculated to lead to a particular Project
 - The number of these may vary, but for each of the three sections, assignments will always total 10 points (if there are five Tutorial Assignments leading up to *Abstractions*, each will be worth 2 points, etc)
- **Three Projects**
 - As described and named above
 - Each worth a maximum of 20 points
- **The remaining 10 points are divided into:**
 - *Creativity Points* (3)
 - Show design-centric work which engages viewers on an aesthetic level
 - *Innovation Points* (3)
 - Demonstrate techniques or approaches not covered in class, seek to educate yourself beyond the coursework and demonstrate that knowledge
 - *Engagement Points* (4)
 - Show up to and engage in classroom conversations, ask and answer questions, *help your peers* (this last is always the most impressive to your instructor)

Examples:

Let's take our Project One: *Abstractions* as an example of how all three projects may be developed and evaluated:

■ The project is worth a maximum of 20 points

As a means of exploration and skill building, and in preparation for the Project, a set of Tutorial Assignments in animated GIFs, sync sound or etc will be set

Tutorial assignments for this section, whatever their number, will be worth 10 points, total

Tutorial Assignments are evaluated by *completion*: to perform them as *described* earns full points

Projects must be completed to a higher standard and demand a learner's best efforts in design thinking, execution and expressiveness

A close reading of the above reveals that three Projects and all supporting tutorial assignments are worth only a total of 90 points —a further 10 points are available through three channels: The remaining 10 points are divided into:

• **3 Creativity points** • **3 Innovation points** • **4 Engagement points**

Which accrue throughout the semester

If, early on, you have only one Creativity point, for example, be aware that this grade will not be complete until the semester ends!

Details of Scale

My evaluation scale looks like this:

A grades	B grades	C grades
A+ : 98-100	B+ : 88-90	C+ : 78-80
A : 94-97	B : 84-87	C : 74-77
A- : 91-93	B- : 81-83	C- : 71-73

As this may not be a scale you've seen before, it's worth noting that:

The range of A- begins at 91 points

B- begins at 81

C- at 71

There are no gradations of the D eval, but the range is 60-70

I'm Happy to discuss my grading system, or any particular grade!

Tracking Grades

Grades will be posed to after each Project comes to completion but it's the grades (midterm and final) posted on Self Service which are considered the

student's official grades

Calendar Fall 2026

WEEK	GOAL	NOTE
1. 08/24	Introduce course / brief history of animation / make animated gif	Friday 28, last day to add or change a course
2. 08/31	Make more gifs / introduce ABSTRACTION : Rhythm in color, space, movement and sound	
3. 09/07	Switch to After Effects: Explore mass, movement, the beginnings of character, add sync sound	
4. 09/14	Project 1 Assigned	Friday 18, Quality/Non election ends
5. 09/21	Project 1 Due	
6. 09/28	Introduce CHARACTER design characters	
7. 10/05	Animate characters, put them in situations	MIDTERMS
8. 10/12	Project 2 Assigned	FALL BREAK (Monday, Tuesday)
9. 10/19	Work on Project 2	GAME JAM opens SUNDAY / Wednesday, Midterm grades due
10. 10/26	Project 2 Due	GAME JAM due at 12pm Monday 26, Awards tuesday at 7pm, Tav Shande judges / Monday 26, Spring registration begins

WEEK	GOAL	NOTE
11. 11/02	Introduce MEANING : where does it come from? How does it arise?	
12. 11/09	Experiment with Meaning	
13. 11/16	Advanced topic	Monday 16, Last day to withdraw with W
14. 11/23	Project 3 Assigned	Wednesday 25 THANKSGIVING BREAK
15. 11/30	Work on Project 3	Friday 4, LAST CLASS
16. 12/07	Project 3 Due	FINALS WEEK

Later Dates

Last Incomplete request: Dec 14 FINAL GRADES DUE: Dec 16 Last Q/Non@
 Reversal: Jan 8 Last day to resolve "Incomplete": Feb. 9
